



What are Psychoactive Drugs?

Psychoactive drugs are those that mimic or interfere with hormones and neurotransmitters in the human nervous system, resulting in a mental effect, ranging from calmness to stimulation, to hallucination. Today, most approved psychoactive drugs are chemicals produced in laboratory settings and vetted by medical trials, but many such drugs, even today, have origins in compounds produced by plants. Morphine, for example, is one of the most potent analgesic (pain-relieving) medications known, but it is a direct product of the opium poppy, *Papaver somniferum*. Today, many psychoactive drugs are used for not only medicinal but also recreational purposes; the use of heroin and related narcotics derived from compounds found in the opium poppy (opiates) is one of the greatest public health concerns of the present day.

Psychoactive drugs are those that affect the mind, resulting in altered mood or perception.

The history of psychoactive drugs does not begin with Western scientific medicine in the 19th century, however. Plants with psychoactive properties have been used in healing and diagnosis for centuries. Moreover, plants have been used to communicate with spirits through hallucinogenic experiences—a critical power in diagnosing and combating the effect of those spirits on the ill health of people and communities, as this is a common explanation of illness or misfortune in traditional systems of understanding the world. Michael Balick and Paul Alan Cox outline numerous such examples, from ebona snuff to cannabis and peyote.